



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

French New Wave

DIRECTOR

Jean-Luc Godard

WRITERS

Jean-Luc Godard, François Truffaut, Claude Chabrol

STARS

Jean-Paul Belmondo, Jean Seberg

BEFORE

1941 Humphrey Bogart's performance in *The Maltese Falcon* provides the inspiration for the character of Michel in *À bout de souffle*.

AFTER

1964 Owing much of its style to *À bout de souffle*, Richard Lester's Beatles movie, *A Hard Day's Night*, has a huge influence on British movies.

1967 Arthur Penn's *Bonnie and Clyde* introduces the French New Wave style to mainstream US cinema.

DON'T USE THE BRAKES. CARS ARE MADE TO GO, NOT TO STOP

À BOUT DE SOUFFLE / 1960

Jean-Luc Godard's *À bout de souffle* (*Breathless*) marked a turning point in cinema.

Not everyone liked its hectic cutting, loose plot, and disdain for conventional morality. But even Godard's critics were struck by his innovation, and directors such as Scorsese and Tarantino have acknowledged their debt to him.

In the movie, petty thug Michel (Jean-Paul Belmondo) shoots a policeman. He hides in the apartment of American student Patricia (Jean Seberg), who is unaware of what he's done. Eventually, Patricia turns Michel in to the police, who shoot him in the street.

Before he began directing, Godard was a critic for the radical movie magazine *Cahiers du Cinema*, and he pays homage to earlier movies again and again in *À bout de souffle*. For example, Michel idolizes Humphrey Bogart and has a giant poster of him on his wall.

But for all his references, Godard and the other young filmmakers of what came to be known as the French *Nouvelle Vague* (New Wave), such as François Truffaut and Claude Chabrol, were determined to overthrow what they saw as *cinéma de papa* (dad's cinema)—studio-bound productions with little to say about modern life. Rather, they saw themselves not simply as directors but as *auteurs*, who would create a new, personal style of cinema, filming on location and tackling tough social issues.

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Godard has spent his life confronting issues central to the future of cinema.

Derek Malcolm
The Guardian, 2000

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A gun and a girl

Godard was adamant that a movie did not need a well-constructed plot. “All you need for a movie,” he famously said, “is a gun and a girl.” The story of *À bout de souffle* is loosely based on the real-life story of Michel Portail, who shot dead a motorcycle cop in 1952 and who, like the character of Michel in the